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to defy salt taxes. By the time he reached, thousands were marching alongside him. Even after his arrest, his followers continued picketing salt-works in large numbers. Defying all notions of mob-mentality and mob-violence, they faced police brutality without either fleeing the scene or revolting.

Gandhi's last satyagraha was his saddest and greatest. After a life long battle against oppressive regimes, this battle was against his own people, at the time of Partition. As people perished in horrifying acts of violence, Gandhi moved around on foot in Noakhali, bringing solace to those who suffered and sanity to those who were about to inflict suffering. In Calcutta, protesting against violence on August 31, 1947, Gandhiji went on a fast that pushed him to the verge of death, but also forced the warring factions to abandon their fights and weapons.

The fruit of Gandhi's struggles were not merely in his victories. What he achieved during conflicts was equally significant: he brought Indian women out in

the streets to participate in the movement, he attacked the evil of untouchability, he brought the Indian village and its problems in focus, and promoted harmony between Hindus and Muslims.

One of the most electrifying chapters in the history of satyagraha was written by freedom fighter and Gandhi's follower, P.S. Sane, also known as Sane Guruji. In 1947, he went on a fast unto death, till the doors of the temple of Pandharpur were opened to untouchables. Gandhi, concerned about his health and upset by the timing of this fast, requested him to withdraw. But Sane Guruji did not relent. He respectfully wrote back to Gandhi, that in this case he could uphold the Mahatma's principles only by disobeying his word. To me, this gesture of Sane Guruji represents the highest fulfilment of the concept of satyagraha: the spirit of satyagraha is beyond everything—even the command of its originator and greatest exponent.

*The writer co-authored Lage Raho Munnabhai's screenplay*